India has not witnessed much export of financial services thus far. Indian banks, insurance companies and other financial service providers hardly went abroad to establish branches and subsidiaries. Not surprisingly, the country's share in export of financial services has been negligible. However, the digitalized integration of financial services in the world offers an excellent opportunity for Indian start-ups and businesses to get a piece of the pie.

Digitalized financial service businesses are akin to e-commerce in distribution of goods. Indians have a natural affinity to both financial services and Information and Communication Technology (ICT) businesses. The fact that most large digital technology firms and many big financial firms globally are headed by Indians is testament to this.

The right policies for data handling are as important, if not more, for financial businesses and exports as they are for distribution services. The growth of India's financial services businesses has been stifled on account of the dominance of PSBs, barring State Bank of India (SBI), which have not moved beyond the traditional business model.

Telecommunications, Computer Services and Audio-Visuals

For this group of services, where India has a substantial share, global exports in 2017 amounted to $1.75 trillion (13.2 per cent). Cross-border services are primarily delivered through electronic and telephonic means. Such services, in all, totalled $3.7 trillion, of which almost half was contributed by telecommunication, computer services and audio-visuals. ICT services expanded at a very high annual rate of 11 per cent from 2005 to 2017. Within the overall group of ICT services, export of IT services amounted to $438 billion in 2017, of which India's share was $52 billion.

India has not shifted the policy focus on expanding the ICT export basket beyond bread-and-butter IT services. Cloud-based ICT services are emerging as a big business, as is Software as a Service (SaaS). There are